

BIG-HEADED TURTLE

The sole member of the Platysternidae, the big-headed turtle is an endangered species from shallow forest streams in southern China and Southeast Asia. It forages in streams, bottom-walking rather than swimming.



18 cm
7 in

BIG-HEADED TURTLE
Platysternon megacephalum

This small, carnivorous turtle has a flattened body, a very large head with powerful jaws, and a long tail.

AMERICAN SIDE-NECKED RIVER TURTLES

Closely related to African side-necked turtles, most species of the family Podocnemididae are found in tropical South America, barring one in Madagascar. These are herbivorous turtles found in various freshwater habitats. They cannot retract their neck into their shell.

RED-HEADED AMAZON RIVER TURTLE
Podocnemis erythrocephala

This species is found in swamps of the Rio Negro region of the Amazon basin in S. America.



32 cm
12½ in

SNAPPING TURTLES

Native to North and Central America, these large, aquatic turtles are noted for their aggression. The Chelydridae have a rough shell and a powerful head, with heavy, crushing jaws. They are effective predators, ambushing a variety of animals, but they also eat plants.



heavily built carapace with three rows of conical scutes

massive head with strong jaws and sharp, pointed beak

tongue with worm-like lure

80 cm
32 in

COMMON SNAPPING TURTLE
Chelydra serpentina

A robust turtle, it often lies in wait for prey half-buried in mud. It occupies freshwater habitats from eastern N. America as far south as Ecuador.

ALLIGATOR SNAPPING TURTLE
Macrochelys temminckii

One of the largest freshwater turtles in the world, this N. American species has a worm-shaped lure on its tongue to attract prey as it lies in wait.

SOFTSHELL TURTLES

These aquatic predators inhabit freshwater habitats in North America, Africa, and southern Asia. The Trionychidae have a flattened shell covered with leathery skin rather than keratinous scutes. The adult shell length ranges in size from 25 cm (10 in) to over 1 m (3¼ ft).



55 cm
22 in

SPINY SOFTSHELL TURTLE
Apalone spinifer

A native of eastern N. America, this species eats mainly insects and aquatic invertebrates.



27 cm
10½ in

INDIAN FLAPSHELL TURTLE
Lissemys punctata

This Indian turtle has a rear flap on either side of the plastron that protects the hind limbs when they are withdrawn into the body.

greyish green carapace with raised ridges



35 cm
14 in

CHINESE SOFT-SHELLED TURTLE
Pelodiscus sinensis

Hunted for its meat, this turtle of E. Asia is rare in its native habitat, but tens of thousands are bred annually on farms.